

Where a Western bouquet aims for mass and symmetry, *ikebana* aims for line and space. The classical structure uses three main stems of different lengths, understood as a small cosmology: *shin*, the tallest, reaching up — heaven; *soe*, the middle — humanity; *hikae*, the shortest, low and forward — earth. Set at slightly different angles, never in a flat row, they make a quiet triangle with a great deal of air inside it.

You do not need a teacher or a special vessel to begin. Cut three stems from a single plant — a

branch in bud, a long leaf, a short flower. Trim them to three clearly different heights. Place the tallest first, leaning slightly off-vertical; add the next at an angle to it; tuck the shortest low and toward you. Then stop, and turn the vase until the empty spaces look intended.

The point, as ever, is not the flowers. It is the asymmetry — *fukinsei* — and the space, and the five minutes of looking that the doing requires. One branch, considered, says more about spring than a houseful of cut flowers ever will.

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Matte ceramic bud vase Tall and narrow — holds a line, not a mass.

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Whitewashed ceramic vases, 3 Varied heights for varied stems, all season long.

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